The administration must also address the state's massive migration crisis. Unofficial estimates suggest that more than 5 million workers have left Bengal for employment elsewhere. This poses a socio-economic challenge for the government, especially as the BJP campaign focused heavily on job creation and industrial revival.

At the same time, the government will have to continue welfare schemes, but with higher payouts than the TMC's. More than 20 million women availed of Mamata's Lakshmir Bhandar scheme that boasted an annual budgetary allocation of Rs 26,700 crore. The scheme provided Rs 1,500 per month to women from the general category and Rs 1,700 to those in reserved categories. The BJP has promised to increase the amount to Rs 3,000 a month, which would require an estimated annual allocation of nearly Rs 72,000 crore. And this is just one of the welfare commitments the BJP made during its election campaign.

"West Bengal has depended on welfare and services-led growth," says Rudra Chatterjee, managing director of the Luxmi Tea group and chairman of carpetmakers Obeetee. "The next phase cannot be driven merely by consumption, subsidies and construction. If Bengal wants to become a $500 billion economy by 2030, it must reinvent itself as an export-oriented manufacturing and logistics powerhouse—creating jobs at scale through textiles, food processing, digital infrastructure and industrial urbanisation."

Industry experts broadly agree that unless substantial investments flow into Bengal, the economy will continue to struggle. Dependence on government employment must come down and opportunities in the private sector must expand. However, the last requires a favourable investment climate. "The biggest problem so far was the indecisiveness of the administration," says Mayank Jalan of the Keventer Group. "Investors were unsure of what to do. We have been struggling with the Kulpi Port project for decades." The BJP's newly elected BJP MLA from Rashbehari, Swapan Dasgupta, believes that attracting at least one major investment project is necessary to "set the ball rolling".

CLEANING UP GOVERNANCE

Dasgupta identifies two more challenges for the new government. "We must stop the menace of goonda raj and cut money," he says. "Law and order, too, needs immediate restoration." The government has ordered the immediate closure of all unauthorised toll gates, drop gates, barricades and collection points in the state. The previous administration was accused of turning a blind eye to such extortionist practices. Another significant allegation against the Mamata government was that sections of the police operated more like party cadre than neutral law-enforcement personnel. Suvendu, in his first interaction with senior police officials, emphasised he wanted the force to function independently. They have reportedly been instructed to address incidents of post-poll violence without consideration of political patronage. This, even as Suvendu's personal assistant, Chandranath Rath, was shot dead two days after the party's victory. Both Suvendu and party president Bhattacharya have publicly stated that no violence or intimidation would be tolerated, whether by the BJP's own workers or their opponents. Restoring faith in law enforcement and ensuring political neutrality of the police will remain a defining challenge for the administration.

If Muslims are targeted or harassed unnecessarily, it could alienate sections of Bengal's liberal electorate who voted out the TMC in search of peace and stability

THE BORDER BUGBEAR

Even as the new BJP government moves to seal the border with Bangladesh, it grapples with the politically sensitive issue of alleged illegal infiltration. The BJP's poll campaign had repeatedly promised—echoing the commitments made by home minister Shah—that a BJP government in Bengal would "detect, delete and deport" illegal infiltrators, particularly from Bangladesh. But enforcing this will be a challenge. There have been instances elsewhere when, in the process of identifying illegal immigrants, several Muslim Indian citizens have allegedly been forcibly pushed into Bangladesh. The Assam government is accused of similar overzealousness, with sections of the Muslim population claiming recurring harassment. According to a highly-placed administrative source, the government will neither tolerate illegal immigration nor harass Indian Muslims. "We will devise a way to identify illegal immigrants. That can be done easily. We will deport them to Bangladesh after that," the source says. But if Indian Muslims in the state feel targeted or harassed unnecessarily, it could alienate sections of Bengal's liberal electorate who voted out the TMC in search of peace and stability. Already, Suvendu's bulldozer drive in the Topsia and Tiljala areas of Kolkata recall 'Bulldozer Baba' Yogi Adityanath's actions in Uttar Pradesh, and the directive to enact the 1950 animal slaughter act that prohibits open slaughter of animals without due certification have stirred unease.

For now, Suvendu appears eager to project his government as administratively firm yet politically restrained. But governing a state with such legacy problems as Bengal's is different from fighting an election. Being 'everyone's CM' is easier said than done. ■